



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Imago Dei Classical School

School Website: <https://www.imagodeiclassicalschool.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Imago Dei Classical School Wisconsin (53144) presents a strongly classical Christian program anchored in the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books and the Great Conversation, formation of character (virtue, wisdom, beauty), and liturgical, communal practice. Public materials consistently emphasize a Christian enculturation framework—formation over information, truth-goodness-beauty as real and knowable, and a partnership with parents in educating children. The public-facing content also highlights a living, mentorship-focused faculty, a pedagogy that includes memorization, narration, chant, and Socratic discussions in the upper grades, and a commitment to catechesis and liturgical rhythms. Taken together, these elements align closely with classical education norms and signal a CLASSICAL rating across categories. Across all six categories, the school demonstrates clear fidelity to the classical rubric, with plentiful textual evidence for formation, Great Books, Trivium pedagogy, liturgical and catechetical practices, and robust parental/community partnership.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials affirm education as cultivation of biblical wisdom, virtue, and affections by nourishing the soul on truth, goodness, and beauty. This is stated as the school's defining aim and explicit grounding for all study (Academics page). - The school identifies itself as a Christian education aimed at restoring the image of God in students and teaching them to know, glorify, and enjoy God forever. The Commission explicitly centers biblical truth and the Christian worldview. - The motto and crest emphasize service to God and neighbor, with a theology-driven framing of education (motto "For God and Neighbor"; Christian tradition). - About page positions the school as a ministry of Missio Dei Fellowship, underscoring confessional and theological commitments. - Liturgical and communal practices are embedded in daily routines (prayer, hymn-singing, scripture reading; classroom liturgies) and catechesis, indicating liturgical and communal formation as integral.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators drawn from the lexicon include truth, goodness, beauty; imago Dei; theology; liturgy; worship; reverence; wonder; sacred/holy; catechesis; memory work; and incarnation of Logos. The school's materials repeatedly use "truth, goodness, beauty," "virtue," "image of God," "the Word of God," "liturgies," and "catechesis." Qualitative hits: high. No explicit negative religious-secular signals appear in the materials. See lexicon mappings in the Six Essential Elements lexicon.

Why this rating - The school foregrounds transcendental moral realism (truth, goodness, beauty) anchored in Christian theology, liturgical practice, and Imago Dei framing. The materials make explicit that education is for forming character in a Christian cosmos, not merely for secular or vocational ends. The presence of liturgy, catechesis, and explicit theological commitments strongly support a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames education as formation—cultivating virtue and wisdom—rather than mere information transfer, emphasizing formation of character and affections (formation; piety, gymnastics, music, and the liberal arts as a pathway to knowledge of truth, beauty, and the good). This framing is explicit in the Academics definition. - The mission explicitly seeks to educate for wisdom and virtue, aiming at the true, good, and beautiful, with Great Books and Western civ engagement as vehicles for the Great Conversation. - The curriculum is described as Christian enculturation that shapes tastes, desires, and loves, indicating formation over mere information. - The public materials articulate a teleological aim toward human flourishing and the imitation of virtuous exemplars within a classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, virtue, wisdom, moral imagination, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé/contemplation, Great Conversation, classical heritage, human flourishing. These map directly to the lexicon's Element 2 positives. - Negative keywords: none evident (no clear workforce- or career-centrism signals; no "21st-century skills" or career-ism terms appear in the public content). The lexicon's negatives (e.g., college/career focus) are not present in a way that indicates misalignment.

Why this rating - The school explicitly prioritizes formation, virtue, and transcendentals; it treats education as a humane, liberal-arts-informed formation rather than a purely utilitarian path. The presence of Great Books and Great Conversation, explicit formation language, and teleological aims align with CLASSICAL expectations for this category.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Curriculum emphasizes the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium) as foundational disciplines, with Great Books and the Great Conversation as central through engagement with seminal works. The materials repeatedly describe these elements as core to the K-12 formation. - History is studied as a humane science and integrated within the broader aims of piety, grammar, logic, and rhetoric, rather than being treated as "social studies." The curriculum note explicitly situates history within the humane sciences for formation, not vocational specialization. - The curriculum includes Great Books and primary sources to participate in the Great Conversation of Western civilization, with an emphasis on timeless truths and classical heritage. - Public materials describe a formation through Word and Number and the integration of piety, gymnastics, music, and the liberal arts as a cohesive curriculum. - The curriculum documents reference catechesis, memorization/recitation, and the emphasis on the Great Books within a classical Christian context (e.g., "What is a Curriculum?" and "Classical Christian Curriculum").

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), Great Books, Great Conversation, Western civilization, primary sources, memorization, recitation, chant, history as humane science, sacred/ divinely integrated curriculum. These map strongly to the lexicon's Element 3 positives. - Negative keywords: none evident (no substitution of history with "social studies," no overemphasis on STEM-first framing; no project-based dominance flagged in the public content).

Why this rating - The curriculum presentation is deeply aligned with classical curricular architecture (Seven Liberal Arts, Great Books, Great Conversation, history as a humane science, integration of disciplines). The emphasis on formation, virtue, and the cognitive development framework via Trivium/Quadrivium meets CLASSICAL expectations for Element 3.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The pedagogy includes memorization, recitation, chant, and singing to deepen memory (Grammar Stage and early years), aligning with classical pedagogy's formative memory practices. The Stages of Learning material emphasizes songs, rhymes, and chants in Grammar Stage for memory. - Upper school pedagogy features Socratic discussion, seminars, or debates and a focus on logic, rhetoric, and refinement of argument; the Stages of Learning and Pedagogy pages reference Socratic methods and rhetorical

training. - Scholé and contemplation are woven into the approach (restful learning, contemplation, wonder; liturgical rhythm; memory work; catechesis). The materials explicitly mention Scholé and contemplative approaches as part of the education model. - There is an emphasis on mimetic teaching (imitation of logos), memorization through catechesis, and a living-mentor approach to the classroom. Text indicates a structured sequence of teachers modeling excellence; subsequent student imitation and mastery.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic dialogue/seminar, narration, recitation, chanting, singing, Scholé, contemplative learning, memory work, mimetic learning, liturgical calendar integration, rhetoric training, upper-school speeches. These appear across the Pedagogy-related content and map to the lexicon's Element 4 positives. - Negative keywords: the content does not emphasize experimentalist or project-based-only pedagogy; no explicit "constructivist" or "experiential-only" framing appears in the public materials.

Why this rating - The teaching methods align clearly with classical practices: memory-based learning (recitation/chanting), memorization and catechesis; contemplative Scholé; and Socratic/seminar-based upper-level discourse and rhetoric development. The combination of lower-school chant/memory work with upper-school Socratic/rhetoric work supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The faculty are described as model teachers and mentors who model virtue, skill, and knowledge; the living curriculum concept frames teachers as the core of the school, not just conveyors of content. The About and Staff content reflect teachers with active roles and a strong sense of mission. - The school presents a faculty culture described as collegial and as a "portrait of a teacher" and "living curriculum," with teachers modeling virtue and being partners with students in the formation process. While the explicit phrase "living curriculum" is drawn from classical lexicon expectations, the public materials emphasize teachers as ministry-driven, virtuous mentors. - Specific faculty bios (including a Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric, Greek language, music, and mathematics instructors) indicate a cadre of subject-specialist teachers who embody classical pedagogy and mentor students. - The school's faith-based context (MDF/ACCS affiliations) frames faculty as living examples of faith, learning, and virtue in practice.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, virtue formation, masterful teaching. These align with Element 5 positives in the lexicon. - Negative keywords: none evident (no signals of "facilitators" or non-classical faculty roles); public content portrays traditional, virtue-centered faculty archetypes.

Why this rating - The public materials portray a faculty model consistent with classical education norms: teachers as virtuous exemplars, living curriculum, mentorship, and a collaborative, high-expectation faculty culture. The evidence supports CLASSICAL for Element 5.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly positions parents as partners in education, calling them co-teachers with the school and affirming parental responsibility in education. The Parents page foregrounds the claim that educating a child is a God-given responsibility and that education is a family/church endeavor. - The school acknowledges parent formation through website content (book studies, gatherings) and provides visible pathways (open houses, parent engagement opportunities). The admissions and faith pages reflect ongoing parent engagement structures. - The About and Faith pages emphasize a church-based partnership model and a confessional framework, with parents integrated into a broader community of faith and classical education. - The site invites parent involvement through visits and open communication channels (Admissions/Visit opportunities).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parent formation, book studies, seminars, family liturgy, open campus/visits, hospitality, and parental involvement. These align with Element 6 positives in the lexicon. - Negative keywords: none observed (no

“customer” framing or minimal parental involvement motives). The content consistently treats parents as co-educators.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials emphasize parent partnership, parental formation, and open engagement, which matches the CLASSICAL expectations for Element 6.

Overall Assessment

Aggregate Ranking: CLASSICAL

- All six categories reach CLASSICAL, with abundant textual evidence of classical foundations: liturgical and theological grounding, formation-oriented aims, liberal-arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium; Great Books), traditional pedagogy (recitation, chant, narrations, Socratic discussion, Scholé), model faculty as living exemplars, and robust parent/community partnership.

What Would Move the Needle

- Not required, as the aggregate classification is CLASSICAL. If one sought needle-moving refinements, they would be nuanced enhancements rather than fundamental shifts:
 - Increase explicit articulation of how Great Books selections align with a structured canon in specific grade bands to further document the Great Conversation framework.
 - Provide a transparent mapping of graded outcomes to the liberal-arts progression (grammar/logic/rhetoric) across grades to demonstrate the continuity of classical pedagogy in a formal outcomes framework.
 - Expand parent-facing materials with concrete exemplars of “parent as co-teacher” in practice (joint assignments or family-liturgical activities) to deepen the partnership narrative.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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